

Structure, Form & Comparing Poems ★

GL-style Poem Comprehension — copy every box below into your notes

✎ STRUCTURE & FORM — CORE NOTES TO COPY

FEATURE	WHAT TO NOTICE	COMMON EFFECT
Number of stanzas	How many, and are they equal length?	Equal stanzas = order/control; irregular stanzas = chaos/emotion breaking free.
Rhyme scheme	Label each line's end-sound with a letter (A, B, A, B...).	Regular rhyme (ABAB, AABB) = nursery-rhyme feel, control, or playfulness; no rhyme = seriousness, realism, or free thought.
Line length	Are lines long/flowing or short/clipped?	Short lines can feel abrupt, tense, or final; long lines can feel relaxed or rambling.
Enjambment	Sentence runs over the line break with no punctuation.	Creates flow, urgency, or mimics an idea "spilling over".
End-stopped lines	Line ends with punctuation (full stop, comma).	Creates a pause, finality, or a controlled, measured feeling.
Caesura	A pause in the MIDDLE of a line (comma, dash, full stop).	Creates dramatic pause, hesitation, or a sudden change of thought.
The "turn" / volta	A shift in tone, topic, or perspective — often in the final stanza or last few lines.	Signals a change in the speaker's understanding or feeling — always worth commenting on.
Refrain / repeated line	A line or phrase that returns more than once.	Builds emphasis, can show obsession, or mark the passing of time.
First vs final stanza	Compare how the poem starts vs how it ends.	Often shows character development or a change in mood — a favourite GL exam angle.

Golden rule: structure questions ("why is this stanza short?", "why does the poem end this way?") ALWAYS want you to link the FORM to the MEANING. Never describe structure without saying what it does to the reader.

STRUCTURE 1 OF 5

S.H.A.P.E. — use this for any structure/form question

1. **S** — **Stanzas**: count them, check their length and whether they're equal.
2. **H** — **Highlight** the rhyme pattern — label it with letters.
3. **A** — **Ask "why here?"** for any unusual line break, short line, or stanza break.
4. **P** — **Pinpoint** the turn/shift — where does the mood or topic change?
5. **E** — **Effect** — always finish by saying what this structural choice does to the reader's understanding or feeling.

 STRUCTURE 2 — STEP-BY-STEP: "WHY HAS THE POET STRUCTURED IT THIS WAY?"

STRUCTURE 2 OF 5

A guaranteed method for full marks on structure questions

1. Name the specific structural feature (short line, stanza break, repeated refrain, irregular rhyme, etc.).
2. Quote or point to exactly where it happens (e.g. "the final line, 'And then, nothing.'").
3. Describe what changes at that exact point (pace slows, tone darkens, focus shifts to a new subject).
4. Explain the effect on the reader (creates shock, mirrors the character's feelings, slows the reader down to reflect).
5. Link it to the poem's theme as a whole.

STRUCTURE 3 OF 5

If your paper ever compares two poems, work through these 5 points

1. **Theme:** is the subject the same or different (e.g. both about nature, but one celebrates it and one fears it)?
2. **Tone:** compare the overall feeling of each poem — are they similar or opposite?
3. **Structure:** compare stanza length, rhyme scheme, and line length between the two.
4. **Devices:** do both poems use similar techniques (e.g. both use personification) or different ones?
5. **Personal response:** if asked which you prefer/find more effective, always justify with evidence from BOTH poems, not just an opinion.

STRUCTURE 4 — FULL-MARK INFERENCE ANSWER CHECKLIST

STRUCTURE 4 OF 5

Tick every box before moving to the next question

- ☐ My first sentence directly answers the question (no scene-setting first).
- ☐ I have quoted an exact word or phrase from the poem.
- ☐ I have explained the effect of that word/phrase, not just described it.
- ☐ I have used a precise tone word, not a vague one like "sad" or "happy" alone.
- ☐ I have linked my answer back to the poem's overall theme or mood.
- ☐ I have checked my answer actually matches what the question asked (re-read the question).

STRUCTURE 5 — EXAM-DAY FINAL CHECKLIST (10 POINTS)

STRUCTURE 5 OF 5

Run through this in the last 2 minutes of the exam

- ☐ Have I answered every question — no blanks?
- ☐ Did I read the poem twice before starting (R.E.A.D.)?
- ☐ Did I write my one-sentence theme note before answering?
- ☐ Does every written answer follow P.E.E.L. (Point, Evidence, Explain, Link)?
- ☐ Did I use S.N.I.P.E.R. on every multiple-choice question?
- ☐ Have I quoted the poem directly wherever possible?
- ☐ Have I used precise tone/mood vocabulary, not vague words?
- ☐ Have I explained the EFFECT of every device I named, not just labelled it?
- ☐ For structure questions, have I linked the form to the meaning?
- ☐ Have I double-checked I answered the actual question asked, not a similar one?

RHYME SCHEME PRACTICE — LABEL THESE

Practise labelling rhyme scheme with letters. Read each end-word and assign A, B, C... (same letter = same rhyme sound):

Line 1 ends "night" → _____ Line 2 ends "day" → _____

Line 3 ends "light" → _____ Line 4 ends "away" → _____

(Answer: ABAB — "night"/"light" rhyme = A, "day"/"away" rhyme = B)

QUICK PRACTICE — APPLY S.H.A.P.E. NOW

Number of stanzas: _____ Rhyme scheme: _____

Where is the "turn"/shift in mood?

What effect does this structural choice have on the reader?
